

THE CURLY CHEF

SIGNATURE VANILLA BEAN CHEESECAKE

Baked • Eggless • Gelatine-free • Hand-whisked

YIELD	PORTIONS	CHILL	METHOD
20 cm cheesecake	10–12 slices	8–12 hours	Gentle water bath

Cheesecake profile: A compact yet silky vanilla-bean filling, delicate tang from sour cream and lemon, and a crisp almond-biscuit base. Finished with a thin, separate sour-cream layer for a clean, elegant slice.

Formula note: This baked cheesecake is structured with cornflour and controlled heat. It contains no eggs and no gelatine. Use full-fat block cream cheese and thick sour cream; spreadable or low-fat products can introduce excess moisture.

1. Ingredients

A. Almond biscuit base

Ingredient	Quantity	Preparation
Digestive biscuits	180 g	Finely crushed
Roasted almonds	35 g	Finely ground
Unsalted butter	85 g	Melted
Caster sugar	15 g	
Fine sea salt	1 g	
Ground cinnamon	0.5 g	

B. Vanilla cheesecake filling

Ingredient	Quantity	Preparation
Full-fat block cream cheese	600 g	Softened to 20–22°C
Mascarpone	100 g	Softened to 20–22°C
Caster sugar	150 g	
Thick sour cream	150 g	Room temperature
Heavy cream (35% fat)	100 g	Room temperature
Cornflour	24 g	Sieved
Full-fat milk powder	12 g	Sieved with cornflour
Vanilla bean paste	8 g	
Lemon zest	1.5 g	Finely grated
Fresh lemon juice	8 g	Add last
Fine sea salt	1.5 g	

C. Sour-cream finishing layer

Ingredient	Quantity
Thick sour cream	120 g
Icing sugar	15 g
Vanilla bean paste	2 g
Fresh lemon juice	2 g

2. Equipment and preparation

Equipment: 20 cm springform tin, baking parchment, heavy-duty aluminium foil, deep roasting tray, digital scale, bowls, manual balloon whisk, flexible silicone spatula, fine sieve, offset spatula, kettle, cooling rack, long thin knife and clean towel. No electric mixer is required.

Before starting: Bring cream cheese, mascarpone, sour cream and heavy cream to approximately 20–22°C. The cream cheese should be soft but not melted. Preheat the oven to 160°C conventional or 150°C fan; position a rack in the lower-middle part of the oven.

3. Detailed method

1. Prepare the tin. Line the base of a 20 cm springform tin with baking parchment. Lightly grease the sides if needed.

2. Make the biscuit base. Crush digestive biscuits into fine, even crumbs. Combine with ground roasted almonds, caster sugar, salt and cinnamon. Add melted butter and mix until the crumbs resemble damp sand and hold together when pressed.

3. Compact and pre-bake. Transfer crumbs to the tin. Distribute evenly and compact firmly with the flat bottom of a glass or measuring cup. Bake at 170°C conventional for about 10 minutes. Cool completely.

4. Smooth the cream cheese by hand. Place softened cream cheese in a large bowl. Using a manual balloon whisk, press and work the mixture against the side of the bowl to remove lumps. Add mascarpone and whisk gently until smooth. Do not whip vigorously or incorporate excess air.

5. Add sugar and dry ingredients. Add caster sugar gradually while whisking gently. Sieve cornflour, milk powder and salt together. Add in two additions, whisking only until incorporated. Scrape the bowl with a silicone spatula.

6. Complete the filling. Add sour cream and mix gently. Pour in heavy cream in a thin stream while whisking slowly. Add vanilla and lemon zest. Add lemon juice last and mix briefly. The batter should be thick, glossy, pale ivory and lump-free.

7. Fill the tin. Pour the filling over the cooled biscuit base. Scrape the bowl with a silicone spatula. Tap the tin gently once or twice to release larger air pockets. Smooth the top with an offset spatula.

8. Wrap for the water bath. Wrap the outside bottom and sides of the springform tin with two overlapping layers of heavy-duty foil. Press the foil closely around the tin and keep its top edge above the expected waterline.

9. Set up the water bath. Place the foil-wrapped tin inside a deep roasting tray. Put the tray on the oven rack, then carefully pour hot water into the roasting tray around the cake tin until it reaches approximately halfway up the tin's sides. Do not splash water into the cheesecake.

10. Bake gently. Bake at 160°C conventional or 150°C fan for approximately 65–85 minutes. The outer 3–4 cm should look set; the centre should retain a gentle wobble when the tin is nudged. The surface should be pale ivory to lightly golden. Do not bake until the centre is completely firm.

11. Cool gradually. Switch off the oven and leave the cheesecake inside with the door slightly ajar for about 45 minutes. Remove the tray carefully, lift the cheesecake from the water bath and remove the foil. Cool at room temperature for a further 60–90 minutes. Do not refrigerate while hot.

12. Refrigerate to set. Once cooled, cover without letting the cover touch the surface. Refrigerate for at least 8–12 hours, preferably overnight. This resting period is essential for a cleanly sliceable texture.

13. Make the sour-cream finish. Whisk 120 g sour cream, icing sugar, vanilla and 2 g lemon juice by hand until smooth. Spread a thin, even 2–3 mm layer over the fully chilled cheesecake with an offset spatula. Refrigerate for another 30–45 minutes.

14. Release and slice. Run a thin knife, warmed in hot water and wiped completely dry, around the inside edge of the tin. Release the ring. For clean portions, dip a long thin knife in hot water, wipe dry, make one decisive cut, then wipe the blade before every subsequent cut. Lift slices with a cake server.

4. Professional checkpoints

Stage	Correct cue	Avoid
Cream cheese	Smooth and lump-free after gentle hand-whisking	Cold cheese, vigorous whipping or foam
Batter	Thick, glossy, pale ivory; falls from whisk in a slow ribbon	Thin, bubbly or over-aerated batter
Water bath	Hot water visibly surrounds foil-wrapped tin halfway up its sides	Dry tray, water inside cake tin or poorly wrapped foil
Doneness	Set outer ring with a gentle central wobble	Liquid centre or completely rigid centre
Cooling	Oven cooling, then room-temperature cooling, then refrigeration	Putting a hot cheesecake straight into the fridge
Slicing	Warm, dry, clean knife; wipe between cuts	Cold or cream-coated blade dragging through filling

5. Troubleshooting

Problem	Likely cause	Correction
Cracked top	Overbaking, high heat or abrupt cooling	Use water bath, check gentle wobble and cool gradually
Lumpy filling	Cream cheese too cold or insufficient smoothing	Bring dairy to 20–22°C and work against bowl with whisk
Soft set	High-moisture dairy or inadequate chilling	Use block cream cheese and thick sour cream; chill overnight
Rubbery texture	Excess starch or overbaking	Weigh cornflour precisely; avoid baking until fully firm
Soggy base	Water leaked into tin or base underbaked	Use overlapping foil; avoid splashing; cool base before filling
Messy slices	Insufficient chilling or dirty knife	Chill fully and wipe warm, dry knife between cuts

6. Serving, storage and food safety

Serving: Serve chilled but not ice-cold. Allow each slice to stand for about 10 minutes at room temperature before serving. A small raspberry coulis brushstroke, a few fresh raspberries and fine lemon zest are sufficient.

Storage: Keep covered at 0–4°C. For best eating quality, consume within 3–4 days. Do not leave at room temperature for extended periods. Freeze well-wrapped individual slices for up to one month for best quality; thaw overnight in the refrigerator.

Commercial production: These are practical kitchen guidelines, not a validated commercial shelf-life specification. For sale, verify food safety, packaging performance and shelf life under actual production and storage conditions and follow local food-safety requirements.

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